



Security Watch

Microsoft Office Vulnerabilities Again

A vulnerability has been uncovered in several versions of Windows including XP Home and Professional. It can be exploited to compromise a system, allowing execution of arbitrary code—meaning an attacker can take over your computer.

The vulnerability is related to the handling of hyperlinks in Office documents, such as Excel spreadsheets. It can be exploited to cause a “stack-based buffer overflow,” by tricking a user into clicking a specially-crafted hyperlink in a malicious Excel document.

This vulnerability has been confirmed even on a fully-patched XP SP2 system running Excel 2003 SP2. Other versions may also be affected.

The solution to this as of now is only to not open untrusted Office documents, and not to follow hyperlinks in any Office document.

Security experts say they’ve spotted a flaw in PowerPoint being exploited “in the wild.” July 17, Microsoft issued an advisory on the vulnerability, which it said affects PowerPoint 2000, 2002, and 2003, and that it hoped to have a patch released for it by August 8 or sooner. So there’s no solution as of now—except to be extremely careful about what e-mail attachments you download and open.

Microsoft says the flaw is not present in its free PowerPoint Viewer 2003 application. However, some people believe that last statement cannot be entirely trusted, and that the PowerPoint Viewer might, too, be vulnerable.

out there is unstructured, untagged, unclassified. Different approaches are needed to allow users to access precisely the information they want. In fact, sites such as StumbleUpon show that “discovery” can be considered an offshoot of search, where people just have an interest and are not searching for anything in particular. Sites such as digg.com demonstrate the concept of democracy in search. And so on.

Search is continually evolving. As this evolution happens, and as people—both users and entrepreneurs—discover new needs and possibilities, the methodologies themselves diversify.

Social search is now just beginning to take off. And it’s not competing with any sophisticated algorithms: it just serves a specific function.

MORE DIFFICULT TO HANDLE

New Arenas For Spam

According to a study by e-mail services company MessageLabs, spammers are increasingly exploring the areas of mobile text messaging, Web-based instant messaging, blogs, and social-networking communities. Bayesian and other improved e-mail spam-filtering techniques have indeed done a good job, but this, in conjunction with the

lack of such filters for the newer communication technologies, means that spammers would naturally turn to these new channels.

“New communication channels are largely unprotected and offer rich pickings for spammers wanting to make sure their messages get through,” said Paul Stamp, a Forrester analyst.

MessageLabs has said in its latest monthly malware report that spammers were “more effectively targeting recipients based on age, location and other characteristics.” Social networking sites offer spammers a “new level of convergence and capability to profile people,” said Mark Sunner, CTO of MessageLabs. Spammers are focusing on such sites, creating phony and convincing profiles, which contain links to “automated instant messaging chat-bot sirens” that entice unwary Netizens to “lucrative Webcam sites,” and then either advertise the usual Viagra or implants—or attempt to put spyware on their computers. The MessageLabs report said, in addition, that spammers are using bait in the form of “friend requests,” generated by bots to target online profiles in large numbers. Blogs, too, already have too many spam comments that contain links to “disposable spam domains,” MessageLabs found.

Link spam, too, is on the rise on both IMs and on the Web—Sunner told

HOT Episodic Game Releases



A money-spinning idea for game developers (lowered costs and more sales thanks to repeat business) and one that gives gamers their fix more often—the episodic game has arrived!

They're too short! NOT

Sure, you get your fix every six or seven months, but ask yourself: “Would I spend Rs 1000 every six months for a six-hour game, or upto Rs 2500 after four years, for a gloriously long, elaborate 20-hour game?”



ZDNet UK, “Spammers send just a hyperlink, which can lead to a malicious site, or a phishing site. We expect more cross-fertilisation of malware as Yahoo!, MSN, and Google become one big blob.”

As people communicate more—and in more ways—it’s only to be expected that where people congregate, the spammers will arrive. Only an increase in the newer types of spam can be expected. Analysts, however, say there is no cause for undue concern—the anti-spammers, who have thus far concentrated on Web and e-mail security, are also starting to look at the new channels and how to effectively protect the public. Which means the tide is rising, but it will fall in due course of time to acceptable levels.



One Silly Question

“You’re playing an FPS. Whom would you shoot?”



“Whoever made the game!”
Amarjeet Singh Arora



“My brother...”
Amruta Dhanawade



“My tuition class lecturer!”
Rohit Patil



“My boyfriend!”
Vrushi Pawar



“Bosco, my neighbour’s dog!!!”
Tanul Khedkar